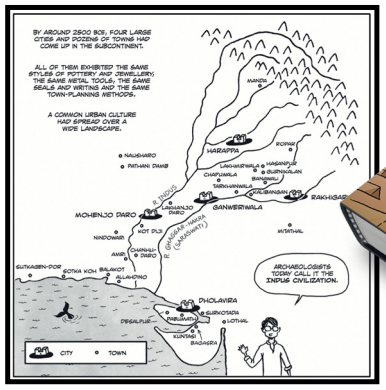
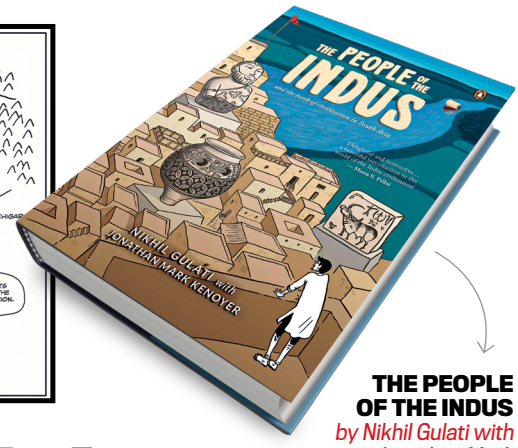




THE PEOPLE OF THE INDUS
by Nikhil Gulati with Jonathan Mark Kenoyer
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA
₹599; 192 pages

A People's History

The People of the Indus **tries to imagine what life in the ancient civilisation would've been like, without playing into the contemporary debate over the 'Aryan problem'**

Deep into *The People of the Indus*, a kurta-pyjama-clad, bespectacled narrator laments: "If only we could read their script, the world of the Indus people would open up before us and their names, their titles and their gods would come tumbling out." By this point in the book's journey, the "if only" sentiment is shared by both author and reader alike about a civilisation that every Indian student reads about in school textbooks. Tragically, for all of us concerned, the Indus script bears no resemblance to any other known script, making it particularly indecipherable, and thus, keeping the civilisation's myths, legends, and the ways the Harappans once perceived the world, a giant mystery.

Through detailed black-and-white drawings, *The People of the Indus*, written by Nikhil Gulati with inputs from Jonathan Mark Kenoyer, one of the world's leading experts on the Indus Valley civilisation, unravels the various facets of the land on which the Harappans built their lives for nearly 700 years. With deftness, the authors have packed hundreds of years of research on the civilisation into 192 pages, with Gulati using a fictionalised story of a family at the beginning of every chapter to get readers to imagine what life may have looked like 5,000 years ago.

Though South Asia wasn't the first to 'civilise', the Indus Valley civilisation in many ways was markedly different from the civilisations that sprang up in Egypt and Mesopotamia. With a simple question—why the Harappans never built pyramids—the authors launch into a thought-provoking discussion over the fundamentals of the Indus Valley civilisation, which exhibited decentralised power, absence of large-scale warfare and the building of monumental cities.

It leaves even the more discerning reader with new information to ponder over and pushes one to ruminate over the core values on which the civilisation was built, the key being service to all inhabitants irrespective of class. The extraordinary focus on providing clean water to everyone, which Gulati illustrates in the book using Dholavira as an example, only cements this point.

The book also places the Indus Civilisation in the context of contemporary India, where it is often enmeshed with the debate over the 'Aryan problem', a subject that has been politically divisive in India. While one camp believes in the foreign origins of Sanskrit and Vedic culture, the other insists on their local origins. Linked to this is the question of whether the river Ghaggar and the river Saraswati (mentioned in the Rig Veda) were one and the same. The book carefully lays out facts that even if they were the same, it would not mean that the Indus Civilisation was Vedic, as many would like to believe.

Further, there is the question of the civilisation's eventual demise, about which there is still less clarity. The authors launch into a very illuminating discussion over the possible reasons for the decline of the civilisation, including the drying up of the Ghaggar in 1900 BCE. This led to the slow fragmentation of settlements as people migrated away from the region. Later, research suggested that the civilisation was part of a larger cultural milieu that survived its demise and that it fragmented and fanned out to different parts of India. As Gulati writes, the environmental and social upheaval that happened around 1900 BCE caused a major cultural churn during which old and new, foreign and local combined to give birth to new ideologies that were truly unique to this part of the world. "Hence, the question of 'origins' seems moot to me," says the narrator. The book leaves us with a chance to agree with Gulati on this point. Doesn't history dished out to us in a thought-provoking visual format allow us the opportunity to take away important lessons from the Harappans of their ingenuity, values, and unity? All of which is beautifully illustrated in this book. Perhaps squabbling over the origin story then, in fact, is a moot point. ■

Sowmiya Ashok



With deftness, the authors pack years of research into a few hundred pages